



A detail from Ghiberti's *Doors of Paradise* for Florence Cathedral's Baptistry. The second pair of doors he completed, they show scenes from the Old Testament.

THE GREAT ZIMBABWE

CIVILIZATION of southeast Africa (see 1106–10) was in decline by the mid-15th century. This coincided with the rise of the **Mutapa Empire** in the fertile, copper-rich uplands between the Zambezi and Limpopo rivers in present-day Zimbabwe and Mozambique. Sustained by lucrative trade in copper, cattle, ivory, slaves, and gold with

into competing regional powers in the aftermath of Timur's invasion of 1398. But in 1451, the new **Afghan Lodi dynasty** reasserted the sultanate's former dominance in the region, which lasted until it was ousted by the Mughal Babur in 1526.

In Europe, Florentine goldsmith **Lorenzo Ghiberti** completed his second set of bronze doors for Baptistry in Florence in 1452.

“ NO ART, HOWEVER MINOR, DEMANDS LESS THAN TOTAL DEDICATION. ”

Leon Battista Alberti, Italian polymath (1404–72)

Muslim coastal settlements, the Mutapa Empire remained the dominant regional power for more than a century, when repeated Portuguese attempts to infiltrate it finally succeeded (see 1629).

On the Indian subcontinent, the **Delhi sultanate** had fractured

The first door, begun in 1403, took him 21 years; the second, 27 years. In the same year, **Leon Battista Alberti** published *De Re Aedificatoria*, (*Ten Books of Architecture*). Both works were masterpieces in their fields and exemplified the self-confidence and intellectual daring of the Florentine Renaissance.

Mosque pavilion in Mehrauli

The remains of a mosque in Mehrauli, Delhi, built during the reign of the Lodi dynasty (1451–1526), who were the last rulers of the Delhi sultanate.



This 16th-century fresco depicts the siege of Constantinople, which began on April 2, 1453 and ended when the Ottomans took the city on May 29.



English defeat at Castillon

The Battle of Castillon decisively ended the hopes of England's French Plantagenet kings to pursue their claim to the French throne.

THE HUNDRED YEARS' WAR, a grimly drawn-out period of Anglo-French conflict (see 1411–15), ended with absolute French triumph in 1453. Any hopes England's French Plantagenet kings had of asserting their rights to the French throne came to a final halt at **Castillon** outside Bordeaux. Two years earlier, Bordeaux, which had been in English hands for 300 years, had fallen to the French. This prompted a last, desperate attempt by the English to reassert themselves against the forces of the French king, Charles VII, which were massing in strength in the southwest of

France. **Bordeaux was recaptured** by the English, but an attempt in July to relieve the English stronghold of Castillon, which was besieged by a large French force, was a calamitous failure. In the first major European conflict to be decided by artillery, the English lost 4,000 men; the French, scarcely 100. Three months later, in October, Bordeaux itself fell again to the French. This brought to an **end the Hundred Years' War** and left **Calais** on the Channel coast as the only remaining English possession in France. For the English, defeat provoked the first of a series of descents into madness by the country's hapless king, Henry VI. For the French, victory brought closer the goal of a properly united kingdom under a single monarch.

In **Western Asia** and on the borders of Christendom, **Constantinople**, capital of the beleaguered **Byzantine Empire**, remained the center of Orthodox Christian civilization. But it faced an imminent threat from the Muslim Ottoman Empire. This threat materialized when the **Ottoman sultan, Mehmed II** ("The Conqueror"), who believed that only relentless conquest would guarantee continued Ottoman supremacy, mustered an army of 80,000 to attack Constantinople; the defenders of the city could call on fewer than 7,000 troops. In addition, Mehmed had the most formidable artillery in the world. The ancient, crumbling walls of the city were



1:12 Siege of Constantinople

Mehmed led 80,000 men against only 7,000 defenders during the siege of Constantinople, a disparity that made the city's fall almost inevitable.

no match for destructive force on this scale, and the city fell to the Ottomans in May 1453.

Conscious of their destiny as world conquerors in need of a suitably imposing capital, the Ottomans were careful to preserve the city after they had taken it: they needed it as a symbol of their own, newly gained grandeur. Its imposing Christian buildings were pressed into service for Muslim worship, and the city itself remained a symbol of **Ottoman military might** for more than 450 years. The Ottoman conquest of Constantinople—now renamed Istanbul—was the clearest possible signal that the Turkish Ottomans were the most dynamic military and political force in the region, and that they were an unmistakable threat, not only to what remained of Christian claims in Western Asia but also to Europe as a whole.

June 30, 1451 French capture Bordeaux from English

1451 Mehmed II becomes Ottoman sultan

June 1452 Pope Nicholas V publishes *Dum Diversas*, giving religious authority for slave trade

1452 Florentine goldsmith Lorenzo Ghiberti completes doors for Baptistry, Florence

1452 Italian polymath Leon Battista Alberti publishes *De Re Aedificatoria* (*Ten Books of Architecture*)

April 2 Ottomans under Mehmed II begin siege of Constantinople

May 29 Mehmed II's Ottoman forces capture Constantinople

July 17 France defeats English forces in Battle of Castillon

October 19 France recaptures Bordeaux from the English, ending the Hundred Years' War